was only due to Akbar's great affection for his mother. Akbar, he wrote in his memoir, 'had favoured him from his very infancy because of the service his mother had rendered…' Jiji Anaga who was so beloved of Akbar as a child that the other milk mothers, jealous, accused her of using witchcraft to lure the infant.

Since the previous expedition to Gujarat had lasted a year, the courtiers had run out of resources and money. Akbar now disbursed money to everyone from the royal coffers, for salaries and rewards, and also planned the operation with the meticulous personal attention which was to become a decisive factor in all his military campaigns. The Padshah appeared to be everywhere at once, his loud voice booming through the halls and courtyards as he hustled his men and shouted out orders to his servants. Sun-darkened from years of campaigns, Akbar was shadowed with worry for Aziz and he rapidly sent imperial tents and horses in advance, and ordered his officers in charge of the diwani to make every effort to react with promptitude to all demands. Noblemen were chosen for the mission and escorted to the advance camps the very same day, as was the harem, accompanied by trusted men such as Raja Bhagwant Das, Kuar Rai Singh of Bikaner, and Shujat Khan. Akbar was heard assuring everyone that though they might be leaving ahead of him, he had a premonition that he would reach Ahmedabad before anyone else.

On 23 August, barely a month after his return to Sikri, Akbar headed out towards Gujarat again, this time leaving his young sons in the charge of Raja Bharmal and Raja Todar Mal, amongst others. Accompanied by 3,000 men, all on dromedaries, Akbar mounted a camel called Jummuza and the men rode out at dusk as the heat rose from the baking earth. The great north Indian summer heat was a force that had struck terror into the hearts of the most hardened warriors. The dust storms that accompanied the ferocious heat had been described by Babur, in an earlier age. 'It gets up in great strength every year in the heat…when the rains are near…so strong and carrying so much dust and earth that you cannot see one another. People call this wind andhi, the darkener of the sky.' But for his grandson, Akbar, the elements themselves would be swept aside.

Akbar first stopped at Ajmer, to pray at Khwaja Sahib's dargah, focusing his thoughts and his will on victory. The men rode all night through the suffocating Rajasthan desert, where the heat was like a furnace even under the vaulting night skies. On the way they saw a blackbuck and